to suggest anything but the driest formalism utterly divorced from any of his previous mathematical studies" [**8**, pp. 1, 3, 5].

Burnside himself, however, had done much to establish the culture of purely abstract reasoning in group theory. In the preface to his 1897 book he wrote that his university teacher Arthur Cayley's "dictum that 'a group is defined by means of the laws of combination of its symbols' would imply that, in dealing with the theory of groups, no more concrete mode of representation should be used than is absolutely necessary" (quoted in [**11**, p. 90]). No wonder Burnside omitted any applications from his book, while his 1899 article on the simple group of order 504 mentioned a concrete example only in the last paragraph [**1**, p. 13]. He cultivated conciseness as a highest virtue. When a friend once asked for a more expanded treatment of certain topics from *Theory of Groups*, Burnside responded by "a declaration of regret that he had been unable to effect further condensation" [**15**, p. 70]. Burnside's ideal lived on in the tradition of Bourbaki, causing the wrath of the champions of "mathematics with a human face", led by Vladimir Arnold: "Algebraists usually define groups as sets with operations that satisfy a long list of hard-to-remember axioms. I think one cannot understand such a definition. I believe the algebraists set up such obstacles in the path of students to make it harder for the uninitiated to penetrate their field. Perhaps their goal, if only subconscious, is to boost the reputation of their field" [**2**, p. 118].

While pursuing the condensation ideal, Burnside decided to omit any discussion of linear substitution groups from the 1897 edition of *Theory of Groups*. "It would be difficult to find a result that could be most directly obtained by the consideration of groups of linear transformations", he wrote, justifying the exclusion of this useless subject (quoted in [**11**, p. 90]). Within a few months, however, Burnside had to reevaluate the wisdom of his decision, as he came across Frobenius's articles on group characters. Frobenius's results proved highly relevant to Burnside's own research on finite groups, and Burnside set out to reformulate them in his own language. Unlike Frobenius, Burnside felt at ease with Sophus Lie's apparatus of continuous groups of transformations, and he was able to derive all of Frobenius's main results on characters and on the group determinant by using the methods